

Leo and the Missing Shiny Shell

Underwater travel story • 3-4 years old



Part 1

Leo was a little boy. He was three. He loved the sea.

One sunny day he stood on a boat with Captain Mia and Diver Ben.

“Ben took my shiny shell!” cried a fisherman. “He is not kind!”

Ben shook his head. “I did not take it,” he said softly.

Leo held Ben’s hand. “We can find it,” Leo said. “We can show you.”

Captain Mia smiled. “We will go under the water. Together.”

Leo put on a small mask. Ben had a big mask. They all breathed slow, like gentle bubbles. Then splash—down they went.

Under the sea was bright. Blue and green. Sunbeams danced. Tiny fish winked and swam by.

A round pufferfish floated close. A thin sea snake swayed like a ribbon. A jellyfish glowed like a little lamp.

Leo’s eyes grew wide. “Hello, sea friends,” he whispered.

Part 2

They followed a sandy path. It led to a coral garden. The coral was pink and orange, like soft crayons.

Suddenly, a crab popped out. It held something shiny.

"The shell!" Leo said.

But it was not the right shell. It was a shiny bottle cap.

Ben pointed to small tracks in the sand. "Look," he said. "Someone carried something round."

A sleepy turtle paddled over. "I saw a crab," the turtle said. "He was busy. He thought it was food."

Leo nodded. "Crabs can make mistakes," he said.

Captain Mia spoke gently. "Can you help us, Turtle? We want to find the real shell."

The turtle smiled. "Yes. Follow me, friends."

They swam past tall seaweed. It waved hello, swish, swish. They went through a rock arch. It was like a doorway.

There, in a cozy nook, a little crab was stacking treasures. Pebbles. A coin. And one shiny shell.

The crab clicked its claws. It looked worried.

Leo floated close, calm and brave. "It's okay," he said. "That shell is missed."

Ben added, "We are not angry. We just want to return it."

The turtle said, "You can trade. Take this smooth pebble. It is yours."

The crab touched the pebble. Then it placed the shell in Leo's hands.

Part 3

Up they swam, slow and safe. On the boat, Leo gave the shell to the fisherman.

“Oh!” the fisherman said. “Ben, I am sorry.”

Ben smiled. “It’s okay,” he said. “We found the truth.”

Captain Mia patted Leo’s shoulder. “You were brave and smart,” she said.

Leo looked at the sea. “We did it together,” he said.

In the water below, fish twirled. The turtle lifted a fin like a wave. The crab tucked its pebble close.

The boat rocked softly. The sun was warm. Leo felt happy and calm, like a quiet tide.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) Who loved the sea?

- Leo
- Captain Mia
- Diver Ben
- The fisherman

2) Where did Leo and friends go to find the shell?

- Under the water
- To the park
- To the mountains
- To the school

3) Who did the fisherman first say took his shiny shell?

- Ben
- Leo
- The turtle
- The crab

4) Who helped them find the real shell in the coral garden?

- The turtle
- The dolphin
- The shark
- The bird

Correct answers:

1) Leo 2) Under the water 3) Ben 4) The turtle

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Pufferfish: A round fish that can blow up like a ball to stay safe.

Sea snake: A long, thin animal that swims in the sea like a snake.

Jellyfish: A soft sea animal with long, clear tentacles that float like ribbons.

Coral: A hard, rock-like home made by tiny sea animals, often bright colored.

Coral garden: A place in the sea full of many colorful corals and small animals.

Seaweed: Long green plants that grow in the sea and wave in the water.

Arch: A curved rock shape that makes a doorway under the water.

Nook: A small, cozy hiding place where things can be kept.

Treasures: Special little things found or kept that people like and protect.

Pebble: A small, smooth stone you can hold in your hand.